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Mike Longo

Pianist/composer Mike Longo talks about the rhythmic aspect of improvisation, the importance of mentorship, and his association with Dizzy Gillespie.

Mike was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to be in the home of Mike Longo. I'm going to list a few things and you can edit. I'm looking at your collection of arrangements over here.

ML: Yeah we just arranged it that way man, so it's much easier. My book got so big, the books were like this thick man, and carrying all that stuff man, and the guys would drop them on the floor. So the bass player did all that. He put each arrangement, everything you see sticking out is what we're playing Monday night.

MR: Good system. And you are a pianist and a band leader, and you must, to make a living in the music world you have to wear a lot of hats, right?

ML: I do. A lot of people don't.

MR: Why do some people not?

ML: They don't have the — I guess you would say the talent for that. Or some of them are not educated that way. I used to tell my students man, education doesn't mean you know everything in the world, it means you know how to find out. And so what I'm used to doing is being able to start a project and bring it to conclusion. Now I've noticed that a lot of my colleagues, they start a lot of things and they never finish them. So I've been doing that my whole life, I know how to finish a project.

MR: Okay. Logistically it must be a challenge to get 15, 16, 17 players together at one time for a concert and then of course a rehearsal. Is that hard here in New York?

ML: Well I don't do it. The way this big band started, I was always out there with a trio after I left Dizzy, I had had my trio, which I had before I went with Dizzy. So I was teaching the guy who happened to be the lead alto player was taking lessons from me. And this agent called me up and said — I was the pianist with the Dizzy Gillespie All-Star Big Band. So the Jersey Jazz, where I played today, they wanted to hire that band. So they say, "Do you have any idea how much that costs?" I said, "Well man they were paying me a grand a concert and there's 17 people in the band and I'm sure the leader got more money. And so she's, "Oh man." So I told her, I said, "I've got some charts that I wrote for Dizzy, that I still got them." And I said, "I got the charts if I could get a band." And they go, "Yeah take the gig, take the gig, I'll get you the music. And so that's how it started, the big band. And he got all the musicians, they were all studio cats from New York, which he

was. He was one of the top lead alto players in New York. So he put the band together. I don't do anything but go play man and write.

MR: All right. That's the way to do it. You don't have to worry about all the guys showing up.

ML: Well they all show up, they're all pros. My band has got the top guys in New York going in.

MR: Well when you started out, was there a bit of a boogie-woogie craze when you were a kid, playing piano?

ML: I would think so. That's how I got influenced. I saw a little kid, Sugar Chile Robinson with the Basie Band. My parents used to take me to stage shows at the Albee and the Shubert Theater in Cincinnati. So there's be a show like Blackstone the Magician, the Count Basie Band, and he had Sugar Chile Robinson. And I fell in love with boogie-woogie watching that kid play. I was three years old. So I came home and started to pick it out on the piano. And my dad was a professional, or semi-professional bass player. He knew this lady, Catherine Rank, that played in the pit. And she showed me a boogie-woogie pattern on the piano so I started playing. At four years old they took me to the Cincinnati Conservatory. Then it was like all classical music. But I was playing boogie-woogie. I won a talent contest in Florida playing boogie-woogie.

MR: Was it hard for you to stick to the page when you were learning classical music? Because you had already done a little bit sort of by ear?

ML: I don't remember if it was hard. I got the job done. I did whatever I had to do to play the music.

MR: So then you moved down to Fort Lauderdale?

ML: Yeah.

MR: And you had an encounter that's one of my favorite saxophone players is that right?

ML: Who's that, oh Cannonball. Yeah. Oh yeah. After I won that talent contest I was in the sixth grade. I was just trying to get a baseball glove man. And I walked by this theater, it said $15 first prize, and the glove cost $13. So I went in and played my little boogie-woogie and I won the contest. But then they had eight weeks of that and all the winners competed for the big grand prize and I won that too. And so when I went back to school they made me the president of the class and all the girls would look at me. I said, "Hey man, I'd better check this music stuff out." But then I started playing with my dad's club date band. And there was a teenage drinking problem in Fort Lauderdale at the time. And so they were starting these teenage nightclubs and they would have bands play. And so there was a disc jockey, he had a midnight to six AM show, Leon Spiko in Fort Lauderdale. He called me up and he said he had — he was putting on a concert at the Hollywood, Florida Youth Center. He said, "Would you mind playing with a quote Negro?" I said, "No I don't mind." I get there and the quote Negro was Cannonball

Adderley. And I'm blown away, what is this man? So I told my dad, you should hear what I heard. Because Cannonball gave me his card. So my dad had a street dance. So he said, "Hire him for the gig." There had never been a mixed band in Fort Lauderdale. We were the first mixed band. And so I remember, because Cannonball, he must have been making about 70 dollars a week as a school teacher at Dillard High School. And that gig pays 75.

MR: Go figure then.

ML: Yeah. And so I hired him for the gig, and as soon as he walked on the bandstand, the street was all filled. It was a street dance. There was a big hush that came over the audience you know. But as soon as he started playing "The Stars Fell on Alabama" it melted everybody's heart and everybody started dancing. And so then my dad started using him on all the club dates. And then Cannonball got me a gig on an R&B band, what do you call it, we used to play the Chitlin Circuit, up and down the coast of Florida. It wasn't his band, I was just a sideman, he was too. It was the Harold Ferguson Band.

MR: Wow Harold Ferguson.

ML: Yeah.

MR: So this was before he, obviously before he left there and went to New York.

ML: Yeah. He was not famous.

MR: Yeah.

ML: Matter of fact he was having trouble because the Dillard High School was getting on his case for playing gigs like that. But he played like he played. He played like he did when he came to New York.

MR: I just love his playing. And when you said he played "Stars Fell on Alabama," he recorded that later on of course with Coltrane.

ML: Yes. He played it that night and it melted everybody's heart, and everybody was dancing and the full moon was out. It was gorgeous.

MR: What kind of tunes would you have played on the Chitlin Circuit?

ML: Oh see, back then, this was before rock & roll. And so, I don't know if you remember Earl Bostic, you remember him? The kind of stuff he was playing is what was popular because Elvis and all that stuff hadn't started yet. So we'd be playing "Night Train" and if you knew the blues, down there, in Florida, I don't know man whether anybody — but the term "rhythm & blues" meant the changes to "I Got Rhythm" and blues changes. So when you played a rhythm & blues gig, if you could play "I Got Rhythm" changes and blues changes in C, G, F, B flat, and if you were really hip you could play "One O'clock Jump" in D flat. And so that's what those gigs were you know. So the one I remember mostly was "Night Train." That was very popular back then. And a lot of them didn't have names man. Cannonball wrote a lot of tunes, they later on became on his first

album. Because I played with him at this club called Porky's in Fort Lauderdale. You know those Porky movies? That was a real place. That was Fort Lauderdale and in the movie it was Angel Beach. And they had Porky as this redneck guy with a cowboy hat. No, man, Porky was a gangster. He was Porky Pineko. And he loved jazz. And he booked Cannonball's group and I was just a kid in high school and Cannonball's piano player got busted for something. So he calls my mother, middle of the night, and says, "Mrs. Longo, you think you could let young Michael come down to finish the week with us?" So she let me go down and I finished the week at Porky's with him. That's how that all started.

MR: Do you recall what you made per night?

ML: Pardon me?

MR: Do you recall how much money you made?

ML: Oh, ten dollars or something like that. That was considered a lot of money back then.

MR: Yeah. Great story. At that time then, by the time you had done those gigs and you were thinking about college, had you decided on a career in music?

ML: I wanted to not go to college and just play, but my parents really balked at that and so my dad insisted that I go to college. And so my grades went — I was working for some obscure college up in the mountains someplace, and I happened to choose Western Kentucky University. And Cannonball was going, "Man, when I was stationed at Ft. Knox I used to go there and take private composition lessons with Roy Harris. He was the head of the department there." He said, "It's a great school because" he said, "there's very few music majors and you'll be like getting private lessons with like three people in the class." So I went there and I graduated. I went there four years. And I paid my own way through college because I was playing a gig five nights a week.

MR: In Western Kentucky?

ML: Yeah. Bowling Green, Kentucky.

MR: Was the music that you played on those gigs different than you played in Florida?

ML: Of course. Man, you remember Ace Denning?

MR: Oh yeah.

ML: He would sing "Annie's cousin Fanny" and those kind of tunes. I hated the gig but it was paying my way through school. But I was working five nights a week and carrying — I did four years, it would have took five years, and playing that gig too. But the music, I already knew most of that stuff man. Some of the teachers would come ask me stuff you know. And so the music study was easy except for I did learn an awful lot about counterpoint and stuff like that. And you know that drilling, every day, every day. There was one class you took for four years, three hours from nine to noon, with this wonderful teacher by the name of Claude Rose. He's dead now. But it was four part contrapuntal harmonic technique. And so I got an awful lot out of that. And the discipline of — when I

say I can get a job finished you know what that's from? Having to play a senior recital to graduate. So I spent that whole year, my whole senior year, practicing for that recital. I played a Bach French suite, six movements, I played a Hindemith sonata, and a Chopin ballad. And so I was practicing for the whole year and then playing that concert and getting through it successfully enabled me to get a job finished. So like when I came to New York doing stuff like writing those arrangements, I can get the job done.

MR: That counts for a lot.

ML: Yeah.

MR: I bet you had to play on some questionable pianos.

ML: Oh are you kidding? I played on some dogs man. Now I don't.

MR: Right. Well as long as you brought up your composing, are you a paper guy or a computer guy now?

ML: I'm a computer guy now but I use it as a paper. I don't — I hear the music in my head and just use the computer. Because like when you used to — like if you wanted to repeat a section you'd have to write it. Now you just cut and paste and all that, and I can put all five saxophones and see what's going on — now I think I'll put that — and before you used to have to write all that. But I will say, look over there, look at all those arrangements.

MR: "World of Gillespie."

ML: Those are all arrangements man, that I used to do by hand. And some of those are more soulful than the computer.

MR: That's — I'd like to follow-up on that because when you have a pencil and you're making a decision it seems like there's some extra thought in there before you actually put it down.

ML: Exactly.

MR: Because you actually know you're going to have to use an eraser to fix it if it doesn't work.

ML: Yeah.

MR: So there's pros and cons to both I guess.

ML: Well now I'm used to the computer, but when I did the pencil I would go into — the best way to describe it — a music trance. And I'd be writing like that. Because I remember Dizzy commissioned me to write a three-movement suite. It was originally for the London Philharmonic with him. I wrote from ten in the morning to four AM, seven days a week for seven weeks. And I swear to God the time went by like, holy, it's that late already, and I'd get a few hours sleep. And when I got finished I had a gig in Fort Lauderdale to play and I said man, I haven't touched the piano in seven weeks. And I went down there and played great. And I told Moody, James Moody, about it and he said,

"Well that's 'cause where your head was at when you were writing that piece of music." But I was in a music trance if you can understand, like you're in a place. And the music is unfolding in your ear and you're just writing it down like you're taking dictation you know.

MR: There's a certain anticipation when you've written something on paper and you haven't really heard it.

ML: No I heard it when I wrote it.

MR: You can hear it in your head?

ML: Yeah.

MR: Okay. So you'd be then surprised if something didn't work? Is that a fair statement?

ML: Well you might make a mistake and have to correct it during the rehearsal. But most of the time I proofread it myself and, you know, I'd check it out on a keyboard to make sure the voicings were right. But I don't write at the piano and so I hear the music in my head. I hear the band playing. When I first — my first attempts at composition were terrible. Awful. Until I went with Dizzy. And I was playing at the Jazz Workshop in San Francisco. And I remember coming home one night to the hotel. It was one night when the band was really on, man, we were hitting it. I got to the hotel and I couldn't go to sleep because I kept hearing the band playing. Then I said, "Wait a minute. I hear the band playing but it's nothing we played." So I got up and wrote down what I heard and brought it in the next day and Dizzy played it. And that's how my — and then I started to realize oh, you've got to have an inner voice that you listen to. And then I went to — Dizzy got invited to Benny Carter, you remember Benny, invited Dizzy to dinner up in Baldwin Hills so Dizzy took me as a guest. So I asked Benny, I said, "Man we were playing out here maybe two months at a time, can I study arranging with you?" He says, "You don't want to study arrangements, you want to study classical composition. When you get back to New York find you a good classical composition teacher." So I came back and I studied two years of counterpoint with Frank Gaskin Fields. This was an African-American cat. He had no talent for jazz. He was like Mendelssohn or something. This guy was a genius. And he taught me counterpoint with no textbook, just out of his head. And he wouldn't take more than five dollars a lesson. And he had a bunch of guys. And he would tell the guy, when I'd play my stuff, he'd say, "See that's what music's all about, right there." And he would say, "It's not worth more than five dollars, it ain't nothing but the facts." And so I studied. He died man. And then I studied with Hall Overton for two years, composition.

MR: Wow. Didn't he do the thing with Thelonious Monk or something?

ML: Yeah.

MR: Wow. I haven't heard his name for a while.

ML: And the first lesson I had with him I had just been written up in *Down Beat*, Dizzy's pianist and all this. And I went and I took a lesson with Hall and I said, "I don't know anything." I walked out of there feeling all dejected. I said here I am in *DownBeat* magazine and I don't know anything man. So I told myself like what you should do is just tell yourself you're a dummy and then pick up, soak up like a sponge everything this man can teach you. Six months later I was in a different place man. And the stuff I was studying I was playing 'cause Dizzy was doing all these tours with Monk, All-Star tours as a trio — the quintet would be off. So I had a gig on the east side and then when Dizzy'd get in I'd just put a sub in. So I was playing five nights a week and practicing. But the stuff I was studying, the compositional stuff, like I would get assignments from Hall like, "Write a tempestuous passage for oboe and flute that goes from placid intervals to very tense intervals. And I'd go to play my gig and all of a sudden this stuff started coming out in my playing, in my jazz playing. And then I understood what Benny Carter was trying to tell me you know. So you're studying that and then it starts to come into your — so now essentially with jazz I'm a counterpuntalist.

MR: I see. Wow. That was very interesting. It seems for many years the thing, and it probably still is, okay you've got to go to New York.

ML: Oh yeah. Dizzy said it, "You've got to conquer New York."

MR: "You've got to conquer New York." What's the first step in conquering New York? If you come here maybe with a reputation with a few people, but boy it's a big city, right?

ML: Well what happened with me, the Salt City Six, I was trying to get here with them. So they were booked into the Metropole. I don't know if you remember the Metropole.

MR: I wanted to talk about that, yeah.

ML: Okay. So what happened was the first night I played the Metropole Marty Napoleon was Louis Armstrong's pianist at the time. And he was the house pianist there. And he went out in the neighborhood and next thing I knew man, about five piano players in the neighborhood were sitting there right at the bar listening to me play. And I said, "Man, this ain't Florida, this is for me, New York." And so when the Salt City Six left the Metropole hired me as one of the house pianists. I just stayed here. And that's how it started. Except I was playing all the wrong kind of music. But I mean I was playing with some great people like Henry "Red" Allen, Coleman Hawkins, Gene Krupa, all those older cats.

MR: Were you like pinching yourself?

ML: Pardon me?

MR: I just wondered if you were like pinching yourself.

ML: I was playing both shifts, man. I played from two in the afternoon 'til eight at night with the older guys, and then at ten to four AM with Henry "Red" Allen at night. And so, there

used to be a place across the street called the Copper Rail. It was a soul food place. And all those old guys from the old school jazz, they were all drinkers. "Have a drink, have a drink." By the time it was 8:00 I was out of it. And the bar tender would be sending me up pieces of Italian bread to soak up, so I could play the gig. But I was learning a lot. And then I got to — I went to Chicago with Jimmy McPartland. And I met this boxer, Connie Milano. And he said he was a friend of Oscar Peterson's and that Oscar was playing at the London House. He said, "I want to take you over to meet Oscar." So I met Oscar. He said, "Why don't you come by my hotel tomorrow and play for me, I want to talk to you about something." So I had a little Wurlitzer electric piano and I played it. He said, "How'd you like to study with me?" I said, "Are you kidding?" So apparently he had this school in Toronto. They had the Advanced School of Contemporary Music. So I made arrangements and went up there and studied six months with him, and that totally changed my life. Like the first lesson I had with him I said man, I can't play. I listened to him play I said, "What?" So he had me practicing 13 hours a day.

MR: But he said the same thing, sort of, at least in a story I heard, that when he heard Art Tatum he said, "Man I can't play." So it's all relative.

ML: Man he had this funny story. He said Art, on this recording was playing this run and he was driving himself nuts trying to figure it out. So when Art got in town he sat ringside, right next to the piano, till he played that run. He said he was dragging his thumb. Playing notes and dragging his thumb. And he said Oscar was actually trying to play that and he was saying it's not on the piano. You know? He said he was dragging his thumb. But he was pianistically influenced by Art but musically he was more influenced by Dizzy. He said Dizzy was his main influence.

MR: What did you learn from Dizzy?

ML: Oh man. How long a tape is that? The concept — Dizzy changed music organically. I don't know if you remember Henry Pleasants. He was the classical music critic for the *New York Times*. He wrote a book back then called *The Agony of Modern Music*. The whole point of the book was the vital spirit that used to be in Beethoven and Mozart and those guys is no longer in classical music, it is now in jazz. And he specifically pointed out Dizzy and Charlie Parker. He said they represented the first organic change in music since Bach. He said they were able to discover a way of rushing at the wind and becoming airborne. So we have this thing in jazz about floating. And Dizzy ushered that thing in man. I can do it when I play but I don't know what I'm doing. Dizzy knew. And so Dizzy — I spent an awful lot of time just he and I playing piano and trumpet because when he would be off he'd want to keep his chops up. So I'd go over and play with him. And when he was dying I would go over two days a week and play with him just for therapy. But he was still playing — what was that — Moody and I went over and said,

"Did you just hear that?" It didn't affect his playing. He couldn't hit a high F or something like that. But what I learned from Dizzy is, I have a four DVD series out called *The Rhythmic Nature of Jazz* that actually, in the order that I learned everything from Dizzy is the whole concept is on those four DVDs. And so they're progressive. You have to learn this first, then the second DVD. But everything I learned from Dizzy is on those DVDs, in the order that I learned them. It's very deep. Dizzy's stuff was very, very deep, deeper than people realize.

MR: Do you think that he thought there was no such things as wrong notes in improvising. I'm not sure I asked that very well, but the idea that there are wrong notes when you improvise, I wonder if —

ML: I'll say it this way. There are no wrong notes but there are wrong lines. And so relief is a half step away. And so Dizzy and Miles and those cats, they were masters of non-harmonic tones with the proper resolutions. Because the whole chromatic scale can be related to one triad if you resolve everything properly. And so if you land wrong, man, you could make it an appoggiatura, a step up into the chord. And so Dizzy, he was a master at it. So was Charlie Parker. So there are only wrong notes if you play the wrong notes. But there is no such thing as a wrong note that doesn't fit the harmonic situation you're in, if you know how to resolve it properly. So yeah, you could play wrong notes. They sound terrible you know. But it's not the note, it's you.

MR: Well said. I wanted to read something about you from the three volume *Grove Dictionary of Jazz*, which you're in. And this person, whoever wrote this, he says, "Mike's style as a pianist is based on those of Oscar Peterson and Bud Powell, to which he has added a personal and contemplative approach."

ML: Well I play like me. You see I never did any of that transcribing. First of all transcribing to me is the greatest ear training in the world but you can not learn to play from transcribing, which is a big mistake they're making in the jazz ed departments. Because that's not you. You're playing somebody else's — they say well that's vocabulary. That's not the way people learn vocabulary. When you're a child you learn a vocabulary. Apple. Give me the apple. You take the apple. You don't learn — you don't repeat a conversation you heard your parents — and so transcribing and playing the transcription is something I don't agree with because you will never get your own — and you can't swing that way man because you're not playing you. You're not playing your own rhythms. And so it takes longer to develop something that way. That's why if you listen to Miles on the early records with Bird, he don't sound that good. It took a while for him. But he was going for his own sound. He wasn't trying to copy Dizzy. First of all he couldn't. And I played with both of them at the same time at the Village Gate with Dizzy and Miles. And I would play behind both of them. And I could see a big difference

between the two players. Miles, he sounded great with his group, but when he played with us, a little funny.

MR: He didn't have those kind of chops.

ML: No. He couldn't play up along at the time where Dizzy was.

MR: Yeah.

ML: Where Dizzy was playing in real time and also his improvisations would stand up to analysis like a composed piece.

MR: I'm glad you brought that up. I've seen — it's pretty common nowadays in jazz ed and the magazines, they'll take someone's solo and someone will transcribe it, and then they'll analyze it, much as I recall analyzing Bach back in music school. And they'll say something like, "Notice how Dizzy hit the sharp 4 here" and they seem to be saying he did it on purpose.

ML: No. What Dizzy used to say is he thinks rhythm and puts notes to the rhythms.

MR: Can you say that again?

ML: He thinks rhythm and puts notes to the rhythm. He told this lady in Florida, "Find yourself a rhythm and hang some notes on it." So Dizzy, you know the tune "Champ"? [scats]. That's the way he's thinking. And he just put notes to the — now the notes, you might be looking up a scale, you might be looking up an arpeggio, you might be looking — but you're playing the rhythms. And that's the way Dizzy thought, and he also didn't think trumpet, he thought piano. The first time Miles heard Dizzy and I play together he said, "It sounds like you cats got married." Because I could see oh here he comes, let me move my fingers out of the way, because he was watching my hands on the keyboard in his head. So Dizzy didn't think trumpet. That's what's fooling all the guys that try to play like Dizzy. They're thinking trumpet. He was thinking the piano man. He knew the piano. And I remember once Miles coming over to Dizzy's pad with one of Dizzy's records. He said, "Right there, what is that stuff?" And Dizzy went, "See right here? I keep telling you you've got to learn the piano." Which he did. And so Dizzy was a stickler about horn players. You have to be able to see music as well as play it man. And so Dizzy could play piano. I used to get pissed off — oh pardon, mad at him on the gig because he'd always be playing and like all the other guys could bring their horn into the hotel room and practice. The piano player — the only time I got to practice was before the curtain would go up. And there Dizzy'd be sitting at the piano, I said oh man. But he could sound like Monk. He played the piano like Monk. He knew the instrument man. He knew, somehow taught himself voice leading perfectly, like Bach, which goes to show you that that stuff is just natural laws man. There's a term Stravinsky used called "ontology." "Ontological music." If you look up the word in the dictionary it's a metaphysical term based on the science of existence. But in a musical sense Stravinsky is the first I heard use

"ontological music." What he meant by that was the music is out there, he more or less uncovers the music rather than composes it. It's already out there. And Dizzy used to say the same thing in his way. He would say, "Man this music is just out here waiting for someone to come get it." And he used to tell me, he'd say "If the music tells you, you go where the music is."

MR: Did his faith rub off on you?

ML: The Baha'i faith?

MR: Yeah.

ML: No. The Baha'i faith itself rubbed off on me.

MR: Okay.

ML: Dizzy became Baha'i five years before I did, but I had been studying it. I had an experience at the Jazz Workshop in Boston where I read it's called the Long Healing Prayer. I awoke in the middle of the night in a panic man. I was like — anxiety. And I called this lady, Nancy Jordan, who was a Baha'i and her husband, Jordan, he was on the faculty at Yale or something, in the psychology department. She came to Boston and she had a pamphlet that talked about when you shed your old self and your real self comes out it feels like you're dying. And so I calmed down and when I went to the gig that night I went to the piano and I played something on the piano and the piano said [hums]. I said man that's the sound I've been looking for my whole life. I still hadn't become a Baha'i yet. It took me — Dizzy almost died once at the Village Vanguard. I saved his life that night. Because somebody gave him a drug that he thought was one thing and it turned out to be something else. And so I said, "Man if you'll let Dizzy pull through I'll be a Baha'i you know. We were out of work for six weeks. And so the next gig was at the Playboy Club in St. Louis. And that club was in a hotel and so our rooms were right upstairs. And so man something told me to ask Dizzy at the rehearsal I said, "Man, can you show me that thing you do on the drum, that African thing?" And the lady that had talked Dizzy into being a Baha'i happened to be there. And she gave me the card to sign. And I'm looking at these bunnies saying do I really want to do this? And so I became a Baha'i and that night after Dizzy showed me that, I got on the bandstand and Dizzy said, "God damn, what did you do man?" And from that point on, because I remember I was playing — Redd Foxx had a club in L.A. And so Ray Brown came to the gig to hear us. And Ray had been at the school with Oscar when I studied there. So he said, "Man, Dizzy's not going to teach you cats like he did us in the 40s," he said, "but ask him questions. Keep asking him questions." So I spent the next twenty years asking him every kind of question. And so that's how I learned all that stuff, from him.

MR: That's terrific.

ML: And it was deep, deep, deep stuff. There were three Dizzy Gillespies. There was Dizzy the screwball that everybody knows. Then there was John Gillespie, who was the very spiritual man. I called him John. I didn't call him Dizzy in the later years. And then there was the very serious musician. He would be a nut until he put his horn up and then this look would come over him and he was serious as a heart attack. I'd be looking at him and say, "Uh oh." And he'd be in this place and the music would be coming off the piano at me man. I said, "Where'd that come from? Where'd that come from?" And I'd just go.

MR: Don't fight it, right?

ML: No. And he too, he had a depth to it, a depth I would say is comparable to classical music, some of those composers, like Beethoven. He had a depth. Dizzy had a perfection in his music that I would say is close as a human being can get, the depth of his music.

MR: Did you ever try doing something on a gig that he didn't like and that he told you?

ML: Dizzy?

MR: Yeah. As far as your playing I guess.

ML: Well man when I was first was with him I used to tell the cats that if I was Dizzy I would have fired me. But he kept saying, "I know it's coming, I know it's coming." And he was very patient with me. And so there would be times where I'd be playing and he'd come over and sing something in my ear and next thing you know I'd go how am I doing this? Or he'd play the tambourine in my ear. Or he would play something on his horn that would make me play a certain thing and then I would be in a different place. And a big part of that is your touch. There's a certain touch involved in jazz and this is what is eluding jazz education today, they're leaving all that out. They don't know that exists.

MR: How do you teach that?

ML: Pardon me?

MR: How would you teach it?

ML: It's on my DVD series. But if you're playing African drumming, and also there's these catalystic type melodic exercises that Dizzy showed me. So you have to learn, you see the difference is there's something, jazz is polymetric whereas classical music is monometric and monorhythmic. But when you're playing jazz man, you're in 4/4, 3/4, 6/8, 5/8 and all different tempos all meshing together at the same time. And so when you are able to play that on a drum, when you go to the piano your touch has got all that in it, that's on a saxophone, on a bass, all that. And so Oscar used to call it touch, time, tone, technique and taste. And so it's not just any touch. You can't play jazz like you play Mozart, with that kind of touch. And so what's happening in jazz education now is they're leaving out the African part of jazz, which in my estimation is criminal. Because that's the essence of jazz. And so they're teaching everybody what to play instead of how to play. And that's a big problem. It's not their fault, they don't know any better.

MR: Jazz education has been around long enough now that it seems to me a lot of the professors were taught by other jazz professors, who were taught by other jazz professors, and they, a lot of them haven't really played in real life.

ML: They haven't played with anybody. Yeah. Well there's two ways to learn. You can learn like when I first played with Cannonball — I played with Cannonball and the next thing you know I'm playing stuff I don't understand — because he would pull me in with his playing. I'm comping behind him. And next thing you know the piano is feeling different and I'm playing all this stuff and it's coming out in my touch. And so that was what they used to call apprenticeship through osmosis. But with Dizzy I actually learned the principles behind it and that's what I put in the DVD series.

MR: I see.

ML: And I teach people how to play the African drumming and then how to put it on the instrument. And so when you learn this drumming thing, this is an oversimplification, but jazz is basically African drumming on a piano. And so you hear guys talking about, "Well they're just subdividing" or they're talking about practicing with a metronome. So I told this guy, I was having this big argument on the internet with this Ph.D. from North Carolina. And he took issue with me telling people don't practice with a metronome. So I said, "Man, listen to a drum section from Ghana. The time is perfect. The depth of swing, the depth of tone is all perfect. When they get finished playing, go ask how many of you guys practice with a metronome. And how many of you guys know what subdividing means. So apparently they're doing something else." So I just say, "You better find out what that something else is," instead of teaching all that stuff they're teaching in the school. It's not their fault man, they don't have the information. But this stuff like playing with a metronome on two and four and practicing. That's the worst thing you could do in life. I've played with Elvin, I've played with all those drummers man, they don't feel like a metronome. A metronome is, first of all, the reason they call it a pulse, if you feel here, that's the way you keep time in jazz. Now you say, who invented the metronome? Man did. Who invented this? You dig?

MR: Okay.

ML: And when I say there's a depth in jazz in Dizzy's music, it comes from this.

MR: Thanks for sharing all that. That was great. You were with Dizzy when he passed away?

ML: Yeah. I was there the night before, that was the last time he was conscious. Moody and I. Moody was staying here and we went over to see him. He had tubes and all — and I walked the room and Dizzy looked at us and went [gestures] and he blew his cheeks out. He grabbed my hand and he was doing like this. So I said, "Man, aren't you taking this a little too far?" And he started laughing. And he couldn't talk but he was just — and so he went into a coma and the next day he died. But he was in a coma when he died. He didn't

482 know who was in the room. But the last time he was conscious was the night before. The
483 last people he saw before he went into the coma was Dizzy — I mean James Moody and
484 myself.
485 MR: Well I'm envious of your experience with that and also all those fellows at the Metropole.
486 There's a certain thing I feel like you must absorb from those guys.
487 ML: Of course. There's a thread that runs through all of jazz, the real stuff. That's why if you
488 listen to that record with Coltrane and Coleman Hawkins, they're playing together. Two
489 totally different styles, but there's a thread that holds them together. I would say the
490 thread has more to do with the blues. And so all those guys, I've always been able to play
491 the blues from when I first started. And so that's the thread. Now somebody like
492 Coltrane, he's playing all that intervallic stuff he was playing, he's playing with Coleman
493 Hawkins and they're playing together. The music is going together. And so I played a
494 long time, before I went with Dizzy I was playing with Roy Eldridge here in town. And
495 Roy is the one that went and got Dizzy and told him, "Come here, you've got to hear this
496 piano player you know." But Roy, that thread was there you know. And the swing. The
497 swing is the — now as jazz has evolved through the stages what evolved was a new way
498 to swing.
499 MR: Indeed.
500 ML: Yeah. Dizzy's music, say Count Basie swung but that ain't the same swing that Dizzy
501 played with. If you think about Freddie Green going ching-ching-ching, you can't do that
502 to a tune [scats]. See how do you do that? And so what Dizzy and them did was found a
503 new way to swing. A new kind of beat and all that. But that's how jazz has evolved over
504 the time. And so Dizzy took issue with a guy in England that was interviewing him that
505 was talking about the bebop revolution. He said it wasn't a revolution it was an evolution.
506 Because Dizzy, Charlie Parker, he could play with a hillbilly band and sound good.
507 MR: This is great. A little while ago you used the word "comping." I wanted to ask you about
508 comping behind Joe Williams and Nancy Wilson and Jimmy Witherspoon. How does a
509 piano player learn to be an accompanist that vocalists want to work with?
510 ML: Well without getting real technical, the main way would be listen. Listening. And you
511 have to have your voice leading together so that you're playing contrapuntally. So the
512 basis of simple counterpoint is when the main theme is moving, you're standing still.
513 When that stops then you move. And so I would listen to something the vocalist did and
514 then play in between the phrases, and then we'd lock up together. And so the singers all
515 like to work with me. Nancy, she told somebody in Florida, "Mike Longo really knows
516 how to play for a singer" or something like that. And I stopped doing that. When I first
517 left Dizzy I wanted to do my own thing. Tony Bennett wanted me to replace Ralph —
518 what was the guy?

MR: Sharon. Ralph Sharon?

ML: Yeah. And I didn't take the gig because I wanted to do my own thing man. I told him I would fill in for him until he could get somebody. But then Tony called me when John Bunch died. At the funeral. He called me the next day, he said, "Man I want to study piano with you, because I always wanted to play like you were doing." And so he was supposed to call me back on Monday and I never heard from him again. But the main thing is you have to listen and move when they're moving — when they're moving you're playing slower notes and when they're playing slower notes you're playing faster notes.

MR: Do you like to see a lead sheet — maybe you're obviously way beyond this. But when I play behind a singer I kind of like to know what note they're going to be singing — at least a lead sheet of how the song normally goes.

ML: Well sure. Well you look at a lead sheet as information. And so yeah. Look man, Aaron Copland said, "The art of classical music is the art of melody." So melody is number one. And so if the singer is singing the melody you don't want to be playing something that's going to clash with that. And so if you're playing contrapuntally you're playing something that complements. And so there was a lady — I'm not going to mention her name. I played this gig with her, man. And she's playing these tunes and she had no double bars or anything, just changes running. It's like reading something with no punctuation in it. And it sounded terrible. And then I looked at the real music and I said, "Oh you should have put a double bar here man, 'cause I didn't know that this was a new section." And no melody, just the changes.

MR: That's hard.

ML: And so instead of playing the song you end up playing F7, B flat 7, you're not really playing the music, you're playing the changes. And so we have to be involved with — there are five elements to music. Melody, harmony, rhythm, counterpoint, and form. And so you have to have yourself trained to deal with all five of those things. And if the singer is the melody then you're doing the counterpoint, the rhythm — and so rhythm is primary. In our music rhythm and melody almost mean the same thing. Dizzy used to use the term the "melodization of rhythm."

MR: Nice.

ML: So it's simple. [scats] Right? So you have to listen man.

MR: What makes you not want to work with a particular musician?

ML: Two things. They ain't paying enough money. And the second thing is they can't swing. And so, but I don't run into that that much in New York man, I mean you know — back when I was coming up that was a must. If you couldn't swing you wasn't supposed to be

up on the bandstand. Now today they make a style out of not swinging. That's the new saying. Free jazz and all this other.

MR: I know what you mean.

ML: It's like playing tennis without a net.

MR: Yes. Some group I heard recently it says like everybody's playing with the time but nobody's playing the time.

ML: Well you play in time. You don't play the time. I could sit at the piano and walk around the room and come back and be right where you're supposed to be. But the time is going on. Time doesn't wait for anybody. And so the old guys, the drummers were more or less the timekeepers. They played a beat that went [scats]. But the bebop drummers, they were playing simple [scats]. They were playing counterpoint. And so the drums became just like another horn. And so everybody was interacting with each other contrapuntally. And so your time is supposed to be good enough to do that. If it's not then you've got to work on that. You dig?

MR: Yeah. Speaking of time, how's our time? Okay. You are fun to talk to.

ML: Well thanks.

MR: If you had a student that just didn't seem to have any direction to their improvising, like it was just a series of unconnected notes and phrases. Do you have something you can —

ML: Yes. It has very much to do with how you start a solo. You must begin a solo with a positive opening statement followed by a corroborative statement, and then ontology takes over. And so you can't play licks or anything after that because the music starts to develop on its own. So what usually happens is instead of making an opening statement the guys just start noodling, and so they're [scats] that's really what they're saying. And so it's really got to do with you've got to get a solo off on the right foot. And so if you don't do that you'll just be mumbling. And so I make my students have to make a statement and corroborate that statement and let the music take over. See Stravinsky said, "Music by its very nature is incapable of expressing anything. Music expresses itself." And so when you hear people say, "I'm trying to do something different." No man. That's not the way it works. Stravinsky used to say, "There is no music that doesn't come from tradition." So you have to master the tradition and then the music takes you to another place. You don't take the music. You can't make music go anyplace. And so I'm a servant to the music. I do what — the music asks me to do something I do what the music — and so yeah my plans developed over the years because of that. I let the music tell me what to do. And so new direction is always coming out. And if you look at music history that's really what happened. Somebody that's trying to do something different is on an ego trip man. You dig? You don't have to try to do something different. All you've got to do is play right. If you're playing correctly — see there's a big difference between

somebody who's trying to do something different and somebody who's not trying to do that and something different happens.

MR: Something happens.

ML: That's a big difference. Charlie Parker — there's a famous interview between Paul Desmond and Charlie Parker where he says, "How did you go about inventing this new music?" He said, "I wasn't trying to invent any new music," he said, "I was studying Lester Young and it just happened." And so when the guy said whatever you read before about me having my own way, that's why. I wasn't trying to do anything. So what came out was I was just learning to play jazz properly, correctly. If you're doing that and you're mastering like there's so much tradition in the guys that came before you, when you master all that the music takes you to another place. And if you're playing properly your own voice starts to develop. So I have my own way of playing. Yeah.

MR: Wow. If you had a niece or nephew that was headed towards a career in jazz, would you have any real-life advice that you might tell them?

ML: Yeah. Practice. Study and practice. Digest. And also, I would teach them the polymetric time. Because most of the people in the colleges are playing with the wrong time conception, man. They're playing the notes they hear Charlie Parker play, but they're playing with a time conception that comes from European music, which is monorhythmic. It's not polymetric time. And so a big part of it is learning the right time conception. And the piano starts playing — Charlie Parker said he felt like the saxophone was playing itself. So often times that happens to me on the piano, man. The piano is doing stuff — where did that come from, you know. So I'm just going where the music is telling me, man, but you have to be playing with the right touch so that you're playing with a touch that is activated by African drumming. I remember Mongo used to make mention of sacred rhythms.

MR: Who said this?

ML: Mongo Santamaria.

MR: Oh Mongo. Yeah.

ML: And so there is a spiritual or a — you can call it metaphysical or whatever you want. A spiritual aspect of our music. Something that I mentioned in the DVD that I learned from Dizzy about kundalini energy. I don't know if — is this possible to say —

MR: Can you say that again?

ML: A word that's off color?

MR: Yeah.

ML: There's a movie called *A Night in Havanna*. And Lorraine got mad at Dizzy 'cause this woman asked Dizzy, she said, "Where does your music come from?" He said, "You really want to know?" She said, "Yeah." He said, "My asshole." And everybody —

Lorraine got mad. But he was serious. Because the energy at the base of your spine man, if you look up the thing called kundalini energy, that's a part of our music. Now if you notice, there's a history of Beethoven grunting all the time. Oscar Peterson grunted. Erroll Gardner grunted. Because they're coming from that base of the spine kind of — and that's got to be in the music. If that's not there you're playing without a bottom to your music. Now that energy there is pretty much a metaphysical thing that causes the music to have a divine quality to it. And Dizzy was aware of the divinity. I think Sonny Rollins, he knew Dizzy was a celestial being. And I saw that. I saw that with Dizzy. He was the most amazing human being I ever met in my life, man. All those years I spent with him. I never met another person in my life like that. And some of the stuff he would play when I was playing behind him, I would say oh my — I would be — I remember in Florida once he and I went down and we were playing with some guys from down there. And we were playing "Stella by Starlight." And I played a solo that was really hip. And Dizzy picked up his horn and he blew some stuff that made it sound like — I screamed. He was playing so — I don't know where that was coming from. Unearthly. Coming from some other place.

MR: Were you playing it as a ballad?

ML: Pardon me?

MR: Were you playing it as a ballad?

ML: No. [scats]

MR: Okay. I'm just trying to imagine what he would have played to make you scream.

ML: Oh man he was playing stuff not even on the trumpet. I mean I don't know where he was coming from but it caused me to scream it was so exciting what he played. I couldn't believe it. I says holy — what the fuck is that? And that happened to me a lot when I was first with him because the first I played with him I was so inspired just playing with him that I played very well. He gave me a piece he had written for Japan and I sight read it. And Dizzy was saying, "Hell yes, hell yes." The next night [scats] — I said, "What, you mean you've got to do this every night?" He said, "What the hell do you think I'm paying you for." And so I said oh man, I've got some stuff to learn. Because he played on that level every single — look — see that picture up there?

MR: Yeah.

ML: That was Dizzy 24 hours a day. I never saw Dizzy ever depressed. Ever. He totally escaped neurosis. And we lived, like he would stay at my parents' house, and often times I stayed with his relatives. And so I observed Dizzy waking up in the morning and then — he was like that all the time. I never saw him ever depressed. And I asked him once, "Man how do you do that?" He said, "I decided early on in life to become a creature of joy." And I asked him once also, "What is your music about?" And he said, "Absolute

love for every man, woman, child, gay and lesbian on the planet." And Dizzy had — if you ever listen to an album called "The Man From Monterey" he plays "The Shadow of Your Smile." I couldn't play it for two years after he died. It's unexplainable beauty. And he only plays one chorus, the melody chorus. But it's so gorgeous man, it's like — what is this? It's coming from some other place. And he had that. It's divine. It's like Sarah Vaughan. We used to call Sarah "the divine Miss Vaughan." She has that in her music too. And so I guess some of it comes from the sanctifying church. The way I look at it as what religion calls the holy spirit. That's what's in the music. Now some people are just playing the notes, they're not playing the holy spirit. They're missing that part.

MR: Great words of wisdom, Mike, I appreciate it. Just to wrap up I wonder about your composing process. If I got a little grant and I could commission you to write something brand new, do you have a place where you would start? How do I start something brand new?

ML: I do that all the time.

MR: Well is there anything that gets you going?

ML: Yeah. A germ.

MR: And where does it come from?

ML: From that place I just told you.

MR: Okay.

ML: I usually tell people I don't write anything unless it comes from that. Where I learned that, when I was studying with Hall Overton, because I would be taking lessons when we'd come into town. And so we were in Holland and it was the summertime and they had Dizzy's whole quintet was in this big dormitory and we were the only ones there. And I found a dance studio on the top floor with a piano in it, and all night long I could go up there and write. So at the time I was writing an atonal canon. And so when I came back to New York I had a lesson and I said I wasn't finished, let me just improvise this, and I wrote down — so Hall looked at it and he says, "Man, you were writing a great piece and you got off the thread at the end."

MR: He saw it.

ML: Yeah. He said, "It's like you said a very profound thing and then tell a dumb joke at the end." And I said, "Ohhh. When it's coming from this part of my brain, that's the truth. When it's coming from that, that was my ego trying to finish it." And so I told the guys, "I don't write anything unless it's coming from that place." That's when I became in touch with that place. I said, "The only thing that can change my mind is if somebody says three grand." That's when the pencil starts writing by itself.

MR: Awesome.

ML: But I've had some professional gigs like Bob Cranshaw once, he did a Latin Christmas record. So he calls me on a Friday night and the record date is Sunday. And Ben Brown, the bass player, he's on the first floor, I gave him the gig as the copyist. So he'd be coming up on the elevator and taking the next page of the score that I'd be writing. But we did get the gig done. But again, I started with a germ. Basically my approach is composition and arranging are the same thing. Composition is basically arranging with your own themes, and arranging is basically composition with somebody else's themes. So the first thing I look for is a germ. And once I've got that a piece of music is in progress on the paper and I just let it uncover itself.

MR: You don't need the piano to get the germ?

ML: No. Well there's more than one way to get a germ. Like there's been times when I've been playing something, practicing, and at the end some kind of accident would happen. I say oh wait, that's something. And then I would capture that and then would go write a piece of music based on it. But once I started writing, forget the piano. Other times — I remember once I was driving to Florida in a snowstorm. And it was snowing from New York all the way to St. Augustine, Florida. And down south, they don't know how to deal with snow, right? And so it was bumper to bumper traffic the whole way down there. And so finally the sun was out and I was pulling in the driveway with my parents, and I started hearing in my head [scats]. I said, oh man, I'm hearing this thing and it was New York, Times Square. And so my mother went to hug me and I ran past her and got a piece of manuscript paper. And I recorded that. It's called "Times Square." It's on one of my albums.

MR: Oh, that's great.

ML: And Dizzy asked me once, on an airplane, he said, "Man, how do you be so prolific?" And I'm saying why is he asking me that, I never wrote anything like "Con Alma" or something like that. Then I realized he was serious. So I said sometimes I'll be looking at the piano and I'll just go over and play a chord. Other times I'll hear a melody in my head. Another time I'll be thinking of a rhythm and a melody starts to happen. And at one point Dizzy took me to Lalo Schifrin's home for dinner. And I was just with him for a couple of months and I see Lalo in this big mansion. And I said maybe I'd better think about writing for movies. That's what Lalo did. And so I got to where I could pick up a pulse from — I remember once writing in London. I was in this basement — in the room I was in the basement of the hotel, so you could see the kids coming out of this elementary school. So I tried to pick up the pulse from that and write a piece of music. It was eventually recorded and it became a commercial for the Miami Dolphins football team.

MR: No kidding.

ML: But I didn't write it for that but it was a real piece of music. So I can pick up a pulse. I could write West End Avenue and 101st Street at 3:30 in the afternoon just by going to listen to the traffic and how it's moving. And I pick a pulse and the pulse presents a melody to me and that's the way I would have written for a movie. I did write one movie but I had a fight with the producer. They wanted my publishing. They wanted to take all my publishing rights. I said no deal.

MR: Okay. Well this has really been fascinating.

ML: Thank you, sir.

MR: I appreciate it. Thanks for your time. I hope those germs keep coming.

ML: Oh they will. The guy on the radio, he thought I meant real germs. I said no, no, I'm talking about motifs. Motifs.

MR: Right. Like a computer virus, like uh oh.

ML: But I can tell the difference between just a b.s. one and one that's coming from that special place that's loaded with that spiritual energy. So that's a real germ. He said, "Yeah, there's a piece of music within that." Stravinsky and Ravel had a lot of admiration for each other. And so Ravel made this statement about Stravinsky once. He said, "The miracle of the 'Rite of Spring' lies in its entity." So I had a lot of students say, "What does he mean by that?" So I said, "I think he means that look how [scats] became 'The Rite of Spring?" He went from that and then that just kept developing and it becomes a whole big — so that's the way he composed. There's a book, I don't know if you ever read it, *The Poetics of Music* by Stravinsky. It's six lectures, I think it was at Yale or Harvard. It's a very enlightening book. He talks about the way he creates music, his creative process. And I remember learning a lot from that book about what we're talking about.

MR: Cool. I'll have to get that. I love that music. Okay. Thank you.